

Why People Love Timer App but Still Leave

Lessons from Fans, Quitters, and Wishlists

Executive Summary

I did this UX research with the founder of Timer App because he is worried about user retention and, as a solo developer, needs to know which requested feature he should build first. Across several sources—user quit survey, Canny feature requests, Mixpanel tracking data, and a simulated conjoint on pricing—we found that **pricing is the biggest obstacle for retention**. We also identified what kind of family plan (seats and discounts) users are most likely to find attractive. Finally, we confirmed that a **built-in to-do list** is the top feature to add next, and work on this feature is already underway.

Background

Timer App (pseudonym for privacy) began as a personal experiment and quietly grew into a product that thousands now pay for.

Timer App launched in **November 2020**, created by Philip, a self-taught solo developer from a non-technical background. He built it as a practice project and never advertised it. He was surprised that people not only wanted to use it but were also willing to pay for it.

I came to this project first as a long-time user. I have been using Timer App for a few years, and it is one of my favorite apps for focused work. When I decided to do a UX research project, I chose Timer App because I already rely on it and want to help make it better, so I reached out to Philip and he agreed to collaborate.

Current State

Today, the app has about **4,500 users**, and roughly **3,500 of them are paying subscribers**.

Pricing:

- Monthly: \$4.99
- Annual: \$39.99

Retention Performance (Rolling Average):

- 7-day window: **22%**

- 1-month window: **16%**
- 3-year window: **11%**

These retention rates are exceptionally high in the focus timer app industry and show deep loyalty.

User Demographics

Geographic Distribution:

1. United States (largest)
2. India
3. China
4. Germany
5. Korea
6. Other countries

Device Usage:

- **Mac**: 53%
 - **iPhone**: 35%
 - **iPad**: 12%
-

Research Questions

1. **What is the biggest obstacle for user retention?**
 2. **What is the most requested feature that a solo developer can deliver in a sustainable and profitable way?**
 3. **What kind of family plan (seats and discounts) do users prefer for Timer App?**
-

Research Findings

1. Quit Form Analysis

Overview: The quit form, collected mainly in 2025, received **243 responses**. Users explained why and when they quit Timer App, and their answers show that price is the main issue, while overall satisfaction with the app remains high.

Quit Reasons and Counts from Quit Form

Rank	Quit reason	Count
1	Too expensive for my needs	69
2	I don't need it anymore	38
3	I have accomplished my goals with the app	21
4	I've switched to another product/service	20
5	Missing a feature I need	17
6	Technical problems	10
7	I find the app difficult to use	3
8	A mistake of mine. I'm very satisfied.	1

Key Finding 1: Price is the Main Problem

- **"Too expensive for my needs"** is the top quit reason (**69 responses**)
- Many people like Timer App but feel the price does not match their usage or budget

Key Finding 2: A Big Group is "Done and Happy"

- **"I don't need it anymore"** (38 responses) and **"I have accomplished my goals with the app"** (21 responses) together make **59 responses**
- These people mostly stop because a project or life phase ended, not because the app is bad

Key Finding 3: Feature Gaps, Technical, and UX Issues are Smaller

- "I've switched to another product/service": 20
 - "Missing a feature I need": 17
 - "Technical problems": 10
 - Product gaps, bugs, and usability issues do cause some churn, but they are secondary compared with price and "I'm done" reasons.
-

2. MaxDiff – Feature Prioritization (Simulated)

Overview: This is a simulated MaxDiff analysis using data from the Canny feature request forum for Timer App. We want to understand which features matter most to users.

Feature "Votes" Ranking

Rank	Feature	Votes
1	Apple Watch app	177
2	Time budget (time limits + burn-down chart)	127
3	Last 365-day progress view	89
4	Markdown support in notes	76
5	Todoist integration	71
6	Google Calendar support	69
7	Lifetime subscription option	56
8	Backlog tasks/list	45

Key Insights

Apple Watch Requests:

- Apple Watch is the single top request with **177 votes**
- The founder does not think a Watch app is realistic to build and maintain for a small subset of users, especially because Mac is the main platform

Tasks + Backlog Theme:

- **Todoist integration** (71 votes) + **Backlog tasks/list** (45 votes) = **116 votes combined**
- The founder plans to prioritize a **built-in to-do list with backlog** before Apple Watch or full Todoist integration
- After this native to-do feature exists, demand for deep Todoist integration will likely drop for many users

Strategic Decision: This path is more realistic for a solo developer and covers two high-vote needs with one core feature.

3. Simulated Conjoint – Family Plan Pricing

Overview: Pricing is a major reason why people quit Timer App. One idea is to add family or group plans so people can share Timer App without lowering the individual price for everyone. To explore this, I designed a **simulated** choice-based conjoint that looks only at family size and discount level, using signals from the quit form and the Canny feature request forum instead of real survey data.

Research Design

Trade-off Question:

How do users trade off:

- **Number of people in a plan** (3, 5, 10)
- versus **Discount level** (10%, 15%, 20%)

when everything else stays the same?

Attributes Tested:

Attribute	Levels
People in plan	3 people / 5 people / 10 people
Discount rate	10% off / 15% off / 20% off

Base Price: \$39.99 USD per year per person

Key Finding

Users tend to prefer **smaller plans (3–5 people)** with **moderate discounts (10–15%)**, rather than large 10-person plans with the biggest discounts.

Interpretation:

This suggests that compact group plans with reasonable savings feel closer to real-life sharing needs (partner, close friends, or immediate family) than large "10 seats" bundles.

Strategic Implication:

Timer App should prioritize smaller, more intimate family plan options that match how users actually want to share the app, rather than optimizing for maximum seats or deepest discounts.

Conclusion

This research provides clear direction for Timer App's product and pricing strategy:

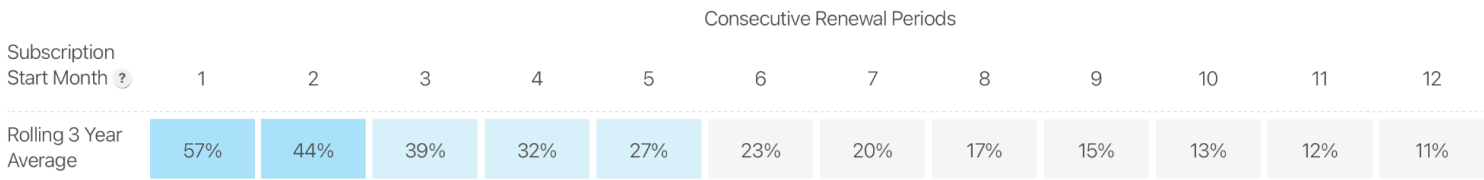
- 1. **Retention obstacle:** Price perception is the primary barrier, not product quality
- 2. **Feature priority:** Built-in to-do list with backlog addresses the highest-value cluster of needs for a solo developer
- 3. **Pricing innovation:** Small family plans (3-5 seats, 10-15% discount) align with user preferences for intimate sharing

The founder is already implementing the to-do list feature, demonstrating rapid response to research insights.

Appendix

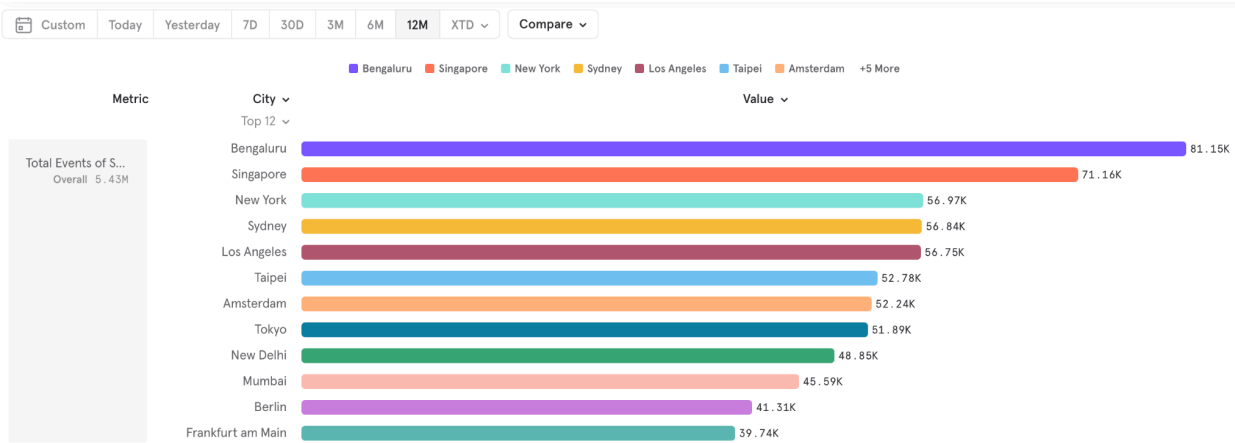
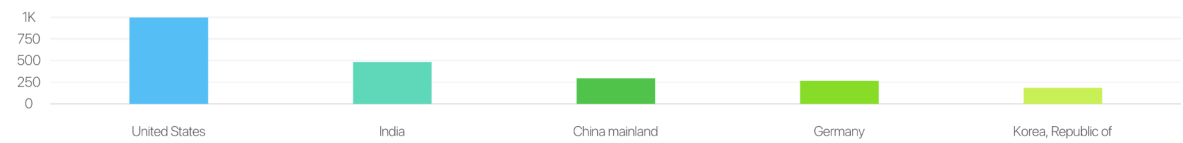


Retention Trends for Standard Paid Subscriptions ?



Territories ?

App Units by Territory: Jan 1 - 31, 2026



```
## # A tibble: 71 x 2
##   unsubscribe_reason count
##   <chr>             <int>
## 1 Too expensive for my needs 69
## 2 I don't need it anymore 38
## 3 I have accomplished my goals with the app 21
## 4 I've switched to another product/service 20
## 5 Missing a feature I need 17
## 6 Technical problems 10
## 7 I find the app difficult to use 3
## 8 A mistake of mine. I'm very satisfied. 1
## 9 Apple ID issues 1
## 10 Below 1
## # i 61 more rows
```

Apple watch app 📄 24	^ 177
Time budget I would like to set an amount of time I'm going to spend for priority projects this week + burn down chart 📄 14	^ 127
Last 365 days progress view Please add an option to view all sessions throughout the past 365 days, not just the last 30 days. This would be beneficial as it provides a more big picture view... 📄 9	^ 89
Markdown support in notes Please provide markdown support in notes editing. 📄 11	^ 76
Integrate with Todoist Sync tasks with Todoist, thanks. 📄 9	^ 71
 Google Calendar Support It would be great to be able to use a specific Google Calendar instead of the default one of my Apple account. 📄 15	^ 69